21%

of the colleges are government-managed, 14% private (aided) and 65% private (unaided)

32%

of colleges are in 50 of the 700-plus districts in India

33%

undergraduate students are enrolled in arts, 16% in science, 14% in commerce and 12% in engineering and technology

23%

students are enrolled in STEM (science, technology, engineering and mathematics) courses; Science stream has more women students (52%)

The survey also offers education of another sort, as it draws a map of the location of the institutes of higher education in India. It immediately reflects the stark geographical disparity. The highest number of colleges among the top 10, top 25 and top 50 across streams are in the national capital, making Delhi the hub of higher education in the country, closely followed by Karnataka capital Bengaluru. And yet, as per the All India Survey on Higher Education, 2020-21, with just 180 colleges, Delhi, along with Bihar, has the lowest density of colleges—only eight for every 100,000 people aged between 18 and 23 years. In contrast, Bengaluru Urban, with 1,058 colleges, is the district with the highest number of colleges across the country. In fact, 32 per cent of India's colleges are concentrated in 50 of the more than 700 districts. Understandably, Karnataka leads the states in terms of college density with 62 colleges for every 100,000 people aged between 18 and 23 years. It is something that policymakers would do well to take note of and work towards evening out the geographical distribution of quality institutes of higher education.

That said, the India Today Best Colleges Survey also trains the spotlight on the relatively new colleges, particularly those established in this century, which have demonstrated incremental improvements. Colleges in big cities or those with a historical legacy do not really need any introduction. But the age of an institution has no bearing on the quality of education that is imparted within its precincts.

Our survey provides an accurate assessment of how a college has been doing in recent years, whether or not it has been resting on its laurels. It lists the top three colleges in multiple Tier II and Tier III cities in the country, making the ranking more inclusive. Not surprisingly, the number of participating colleges has nearly doubled in the past five years—from 988 in 2018 to 1,715 this year. Educationists acknowledge that the exercise has sparked a competitive spirit among colleges from even smaller cities and given them the motivation to do better. The gainer, ultimately, will be the higher education sector in the country, as well as the students and the country. Since 1997, the year our journey began, this is what has motivated us—to capture the positive changes in India's colleges and fostering competition among them so that we move towards collective excellence. ■

METHODOLOGY

HOW THE COLLEGES WERE RANKED

With more than 43,000 colleges in the country, the India Today Group's college ranking strives to make critical career decision easier for aspirants and guide stakeholders such as recruiters, parents, alumni, policymakers, general public and institutions. Since 2018, this survey has been conducted in association with Delhi-based market research agency Marketing & Development Research Associates (MDRA). The groundwork this year was conducted between December 2022 and June 2023. Colleges were ranked in 14 streams—Arts, Science, Commerce, Medical, Dental Sciences, Engineering, Architecture, Law, Mass Communication, Hotel Management, BBA, BCA, Social Work and Fashion Design.

For objective ranking, MDRA tuned over 112 performance indicators in each stream and clubbed them under five broad parameters—'Intake Quality and Governance', 'Academic Excellence', 'Infrastructure and Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'. In addition, colleges were assessed on how